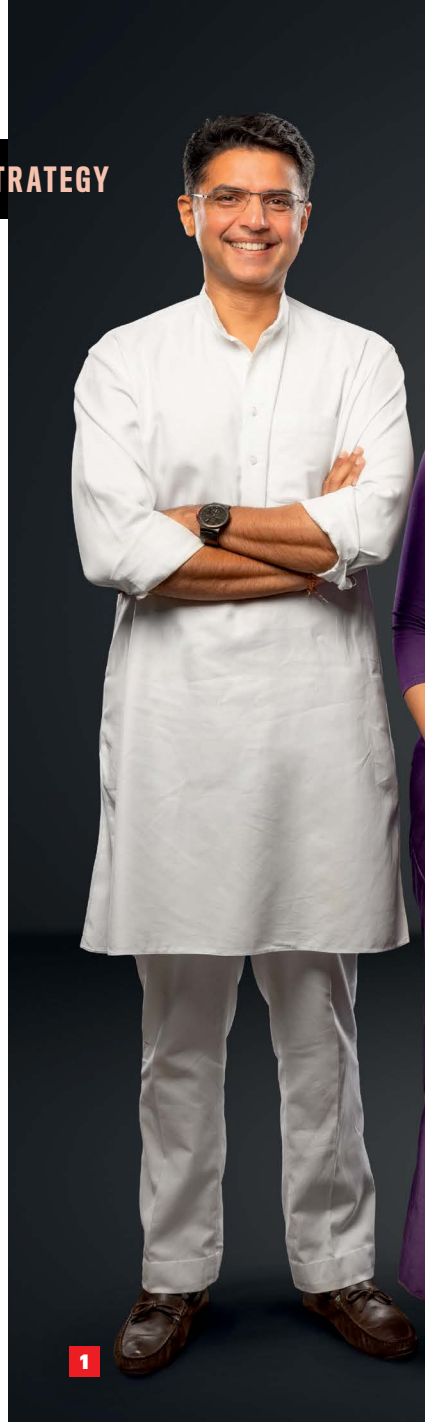
ON A WING AND A PRAYER

Since June 2023, when the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (I.N.D.I.A.) was formed, the 28-party Opposition grouping has gone through several periods of political turbulence. The objective of the formation was to put up a united fight to avoid a split in the votes against the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in the 2019 Lok Sabha election.

On the ground, though, I.N.D.I.A.'s arithmetic has not added up so far. Founder-member and Janata Dal (United) leader Nitish Kumar has decamped to the BJP side, Mamata Banerjee's s Trinamool Congress has decided to go solo in West Bengal and the Northeast; in Kerala, the Left parties are putting up candidates against ally Congress. More than all this, the I.N.D.I.A. bloc has failed to come up with a coherent narrative against the BJP other than criticism of Prime Minister Narendra Modi which, as the National Conference's Omar Abdullah admitted, hasn't stuck on the teflon-coated PM. They have talked about the threat to India's democratic norms and institutions and marginalisation of the minorities, but a common alliance agenda is nowhere in sight. Sachin Pilot of the Congress, though, is still optimistic: "Don't forget, in 2019, the BJP won less than 37 per cent of the vote. That means two-thirds of the voters who went to the polling booth voted against the BJP."

Even on contentious issues like the abrogation of Article 370, the alliance members lack consensus. But, as Abdullah put it, "That is the beauty of the alliance...we agree to disagree on some issues, but it hasn't pulled us apart." The Aam Aadmi Party's powerhouse minister Atishi agrees—regional and past rivalries aside, this is a battle for democracy and the Constitution. That said, apart from Pilot, the two other leaders were unwilling to hazard a guess on where the I.N.D.I.A. tally would land. ■



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AS THE OPPOSITION, WE ARE WITHIN OUR RIGHTS TO ASK QUESTIONS, ASK FOR TRANSPARENCY, DEBATE, DISCUSSION. SHOULD WE NOT ASK WHY 147 MPS WERE SUSPENDED IN A SINGLE DAY AND BILLS WERE PASSED.... WHO'S GOING TO DO THAT? UNFORTUNATELY, IT HASN'T BEEN THE MEDIA, SO IT HAS TO BE THE OPPOSITION

THE ED AND CBI HAVE BECOME LIKE STREET THUGS, THE BJP GOVERNMENT'S GOONS, BEATING UP OPPONENTS AND DEMANDING PROTECTION MONEY IN THE FORM OF ELECTORAL BONDS. THAT IS THE STATE OF THE CONSTITUTION OF OUR COUNTRY. THAT IS THE STATE OF DEMOCRACY IN THIS COUNTRY

1. SACHIN PILOT
Congress MLA in Rajasthan, AICC in-charge of Chhattisgarh

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The I.N.D.I.A. bloc's main strategy is to put up a common candidate to consolidate non-NDA votes, but internal contradictions remain a challenge. It claims seat-sharing arrangements in most states have been sealed